major European countries, while others ruled only a few villages. Some of them had survived from before the Islamic conquests. It says a lot about the spirit of the times and the persuasive powers of the negotiators that, after a lot of grumbling, the occasional theatrics and some last-minute bargaining, almost all of them signed over their kingdoms to the new democracy by the 15 August deadline (of course, some also opted for Pakistan). There were three important exceptions to this—Junagarh in the west, Hyderabad in the south, and Jammu and Kashmir in the extreme north. The first two had Muslim rulers but a Hindu-majority population, while the reverse was true of Jammu and Kashmir.

Junagarh was not just wedged within Indian territory but was also of great symbolic value. Within its borders were the ancient temple of Somnath and the sacred hill of Girnar with its numerous Hindu–Jain temples. At the base of the hill, and a short walk from the Junagarh fort, are the rock inscriptions of Ashoka, Rudradaman and Skandagupta. In addition, it is home to the last Asiatic lions left in the wild. In 1947, it was ruled by Nawab Mohabat Khan, best remembered for his love of dogs. It is said that he owned 2000 pedigree dogs and that when two of his favourites mated, the ‘wedding’ was celebrated as a State event.

In the summer of 1947, Mohabat Khan was on holiday in Europe but had left the country in hands of his Dewan, Sir Shah Nawaz Bhutto, a Sindhi politician and the father of future Pakistan Prime Minister Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. When the Nawab returned, Bhutto convinced him to opt out of India. On 14 August 1947, just hours before the handover, Junagarh declared itself for Pakistan! A few weeks later, Pakistan accepted the accession. The local population, 82 per cent Hindu, and India’s leaders were enraged. Deputy Prime Minister Patel, himself a Gujarati, responded by getting two of Junagarh’s vassal states to declare for India. A small military force was sent in to support them. Meanwhile, a popular agitation began to gather momentum. The Nawab panicked and fled to Karachi, taking with him a dozen of his favourite dogs! With his back to the wall, Sir Shah Nawaz agreed to a plebiscite that overwhelmingly voted in favour of India.